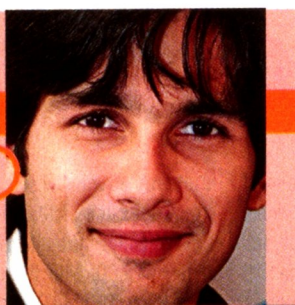


THE BRAT Pack

These men are the mascots of a new India

SHAHID KAPOOR 29

Has had critical and commercial successes in *Jab We Met* and *Kaminey*. The latest *Badmaash Company* didn't tank but his movies need to stand for something.



ABHAY DEOL 34

Is not afraid to take a chance. Looks for movies that shatter form and content. Is finally playing it clean cut in *Aisha*, the homegrown adaptation of *Emma*.



IMRAN KHAN 27

Was born to play the loverboy. Is beloved by girls of all ages, except when he wears tan make-up and builds muscle for movies like *Luck* and *Kidnap*. His *I Hate Luv Storys* looks like melting chocolate.



learning every day," he says. He took a hiatus, spending a year "getting to know myself," and doing an hour each of Hindi diction, action and dance. Taking his father's advice, he watched the great Indian masters, from Guru Dutt to Bimal Roy, from Mehboob Khan to Raj Kapoor. Then *Saawariya* happened and his rocket was up and away despite the film crashlanding.

Born into a family where marble swans share space with Lalique crystal horses, where Abu-Sandeep tapestries are draped casually next to Jehangir Sabavala paintings, he is motivated by finding his place in the family history. He's not working to enjoy the perks of life. Work is the perk of life for him. If Raj Kapoor was the loving grandfather who washed his feet when he was bitten by red ants while playing in the garden of RK

House in Chembur, he is also an enormous shadow that sons Randhir and Rishi struggled to emerge from. Bollywood families crowd the road he has lived on since 1989. One star son, Sanjay Dutt, whose gym he often uses, has had more twists and turns in his life than a NASCAR race track. Another Pali Hill neighbour, Imran Khan, has also seen how temporary success can be. Ranbir's own father's rants, fuelled by his decline as a leading man and perhaps generous doses of Scotch, are not something he will forget in a hurry. With so many markers pointing him to possible self-destruction, it is unlikely that his intelligence will let him down. Mukerji, the wisest 26-year-old in Bollywood, says he needs to just do the films he wants to, not what others want him to.

"I learn from everything, whether reading a book or sleeping with a girl."

Ranbir shows a smart head by keeping his lifestyle simple despite the money in the bank that his father handles, "because I don't understand numbers". He travels with his make-up man, a hairstylist and the spotboy, three men who tell him exactly when he's good and when he's horrid. He has a manager who handles his six endorsements: Pepsi, John Players, Virgin Mobile, Panasonic, Nissan Micra, and soon Hero Honda. He shares a manager with his father, the venerable Shanti Malik, who is the guardian at the gate, occupying a room leading up to the house which is littered with silver jubilee trophies of films which fed off the Rishi Kapoor charisma. There's a story behind each plaque and Shantiji as he is called, he of the polished black hair and equally shiny shoes, is a great storyteller. There's *Nagina*, after which "Chintuji" became the highest taxpayer in Bollywood. There's *Deewana* where Shah Rukh Khan started, which he acknowledged

RANBIR WITH PARENTS RISHI AND NEETU KAPOOR AT AN AWARD FUNCTION

